

Internal Linking

The only authority signal you fully control, and the one most sites leave sitting unused.

Bottom line

Internal links do three things: they distribute authority, they tell search engines what a page is about through anchor text, and they make the cluster structure from Section 15 legible.

Bidirectional pillar linking is reported to raise AI citation probability 2.7x. Unlike backlinks, none of this requires anyone else's cooperation.

What internal links do

Distribute authority. Pages that receive links, internally and externally, accumulate authority and pass some of it on. Your homepage usually holds the most. Every internal link is a decision about where that flows.

Describe the target. Anchor text is one of the clearest statements you can make about what a page covers. This is why "click here" is a wasted link.

Establish relationships. The pillar-to-cluster structure only exists to a machine if the links exist.

Enable discovery. From Section 2, a page with no internal links is effectively invisible. Crawlers find pages by following links.

The working thresholds

Guideline	Value	Tier
Internal links per 2,000 words	8 to 15	[practitioner]
Bidirectional pillar-cluster linking	reported 2.7x AI citation probability	[practitioner]
Clicks from homepage to any commercial page	3 maximum	[practitioner]
Orphan pages	zero	

Treat 8 to 15 as a sanity range, not a quota. Links should exist because they are useful.

Anchor text

Be specific and descriptive. The anchor should tell you where you are going without the surrounding sentence.

- Bad: "click here", "read more", "this article", "learn more"
- Better: "how crawl budget works", "the 60-second difficulty read"

Vary it naturally. Ten links to the same page with identical exact-match anchors reads as manipulation. Different pages will naturally describe the target differently, which is fine and correct.

Do not over-optimize. Internal anchors are a signal you fully control, which means aggressive exact-match anchoring is easy to detect. Write what the link is genuinely about.

Anchor text builds the semantic map. Consistent, topically specific anchors are how a retrieval system understands that a set of pages belongs together. [practitioner]

Where links should come from

Contextual links inside body content are the strongest. A link in a sentence, where the surrounding text explains why the target is relevant, carries more weight than a link in a sidebar or footer.

Navigation links are powerful but blunt. Everything in the main nav is linked from every page. That is why Section 13 argues for keeping the nav small.

Footer links are weak. Sitewide, low context, largely discounted. A footer stuffed with keyword-anchored links is a recognizable pattern and not a good one.

Related-posts modules are fine but automated, so they tend to be topically loose. They do not replace deliberate contextual linking.

Building the cluster links

From your Section 15 link map:

- 1 Pillar links down to every cluster page.** In context, where the pillar summarizes that sub-topic. A block of fifteen links at the bottom is weaker than fifteen links placed where each is relevant.
- 2 Every cluster page links back up to the pillar.** Usually early, often in the opening context.
- 3 Cluster pages link sideways** where genuinely relevant. Do not force a complete graph.
- 4 Your most important commercial page gets links from the highest-authority pages** you have. Look at which of your pages have the most external links or the most traffic, and link from those.

Finding what is missing

Orphan pages. Crawl the site with Screaming Frog's free tier, up to 500 URLs, and check the orphan report. Or cross-reference indexed URLs in Search Console against your crawl. Every orphan either

gets a link or gets removed.

Under-linked important pages. For each page in your top 10 priorities, count internal links pointing at it. If your most commercially important page has two internal links and a 2019 blog post has thirty, your authority is flowing to the wrong place.

Missed opportunities. Search `site:yourdomain.com "topic phrase"` to find every page mentioning a topic. Any of those pages that mentions the topic without linking to your page about it is a missing link. This is the fastest way to find dozens of real opportunities.

Broken internal links. Any 404 from an internal link wastes authority entirely. Screaming Frog reports these.

Links through redirects. From Section 13, an internal link pointing at a URL that 301s somewhere else leaks a little signal and adds latency. Point internal links at final URLs.

Common mistakes

- **Linking everything to the homepage.** It already has the most authority. It does not need yours.
- **The same link repeated in every paragraph.** Once per page, in the most relevant place.
- **Only linking to new content.** Older pages that already have authority are often the better link sources.
- **No links out of high-traffic pages.** If a page gets traffic and links nowhere useful, that attention dead-ends.

Why this matters

backlinks require somebody else to decide you are worth linking to. Internal links require nothing but a decision. It is the largest lever most sites have never pulled, and the entire cluster structure from Section 15 is inert without it.

Do this now

- 1 **Crawl your site** with Screaming Frog free tier, or list your URLs manually if the site is small.
- 2 **Find every orphan page.** Link it from somewhere relevant, or remove it.
- 3 **Count internal links to your top 10 priority pages.** Note any that are under-linked relative to their importance.
- 4 **Run the site: search** for your three most important topics. Find pages that mention the topic without linking to your page about it. Add those links. Expect to find more than you thought.
- 5 **Build the cluster links** from your Section 15 map: pillar down to every cluster, every cluster back up, placed contextually rather than in a block.
- 6 **Fix every internal link pointing at a redirect or a 404.**

- 7 Audit your anchor text.** Replace every "click here" and "read more" with something descriptive.
- 8 Check the 3-click rule.** Can you reach every commercial page within three clicks of the homepage?

Capstone step

Your cluster is now wired: pillar and cluster pages linked bidirectionally in context, orphans resolved, priority pages properly linked, anchors descriptive, and no internal links pointing at redirects or 404s. The structure from Section 15 is now legible to machines.

Key takeaways

- Internal linking is the only authority signal that needs nobody's permission, and it is the largest unused lever on most sites.
- Bidirectional pillar-cluster linking is reported at 2.7x AI citation probability. Roughly 8 to 15 contextual links per 2,000 words is a sane range.
- Anchor text should describe the destination specifically. "Click here" wastes the clearest statement you can make about a page.
- The `site:` search for a topic finds pages that mention it without linking to your page about it. That single technique usually surfaces dozens of real opportunities.